acquisition of the steamers. Written from Palayamkottai it addressed VOC as ‘Apostle of Swadeshism, Bombay’:[13]

> Mr. Vedamurthi Mudaliar would have talked to you all about me and the awkward predicament in which I now find myself … He has told me to find in you another S.V. [Vedamurthi] Mudaliar and directed me to seek necessary help and patronage from your good and patriotic self … I have not seen you in flesh and bone, but I have heard enough of the virtues of your head and heart and of your self-sacrificing and patriotic labours in Swadeshi cause. I doubt if there is a second patriot in southern parts to be equalled with you in your love of our downtrodden country and countrymen. I am anxious to see you in person to pay my respects to such a lofty and exalted patriot and make his esteemed acquaintance … I came here to serve my country as a journalist but still this hope is not gone so long as you and Mr. S.V. are alive …

Even discounting the ingratiating tone, this letter speaks to VOC’s fast-spreading fame. S. Vedamurthi Mudaliar, editor of the *People’s Guardian*, was, as we shall see, the man VOC deputed to Europe to acquire the steamers. Earlier VOC had also inducted him as a secretary of SSNCo. A few days later, on 3 February, we have Thambusami Pillai writing to Parali S. Shanmugasundaram Pillai, addressing him as ‘Dear Brother’:[14]

> Your affectionate letter has quite touched my heart and consoled me very much … I thank you for your kind note on behalf of Mr V.O. Chidambaram Pillay … Anything you could possibly send will be of help to me and … I will have them paid up forthwith with supreme thankfulness …

Exhibited along with this letter is an IOU signed by Thambusami Pillai.

> On demand I promise to pay S. Somasundara Bharati, B.A., B.L., Manager, Swadeshi Steam Navigation Company Ltd., or order, the sum of Rupees twelve and half only with interest at 12% per annum for value received.[15]

From these two documents we see that VOC had responded favourably to Thambusami Pillai’s request and instructed his trusted lieutenant not only to hire him but also advance money to him. Following this, ten days later, Thambusami Pillai wrote to VOC in Bombay.[16]

> I sincerely thank you for the kind help accorded and it is my favourable desire to serve the noble cause of our country with a patriot, whose life and example … so inspiring and